



FRICITION: Bapu (left); a protest against the boys' deaths (below)

Even Bapu's 15-acre Ahmedabad ashram is clouded in controversy because the gurukul building on its premises is illegal. Not just that, the ashram land at Karol Bagh in Delhi and the 25-acre proposed ashram in Rajokri village near Delhi are also wrapped in court cases. We have had a very bad experience from Bapu's disciples," says Ohmvir Singh Chauhan, thakur of Panchd near Ratlam in Madhya Pradesh. According to Chauhan, in the early '90s Bapu's disciples encroached upon 26 acres of his family estate. This led to a court battle, but in the end the family had to sell the estate to the followers because it didn't have the stomach to take on Bapu's aggressive disciples.

Bapu's business empire rests on the sale of over two dozen products across his satsang centres and other facilities. Insiders allege that ashram authorities manipulate records to avoid paying taxes. The magazines—*Rushiprasad*, a monthly in several languages, and the fortnightly *Lok Kalyan Setu*, sell 14 lakh copies every month, netting around Rs 7.50 crore annually. But the bigger grossers are the 50-odd satsang discourses Bapu delivers to his followers. Each two or three-day discourse nets Rs 1 crore via sales of associated products and what he gets from the organisers. The biggest money spinners, however, are the three to four annual Gurupurnima functions during which Bapu receives donations running into crores of rupees.

The godman's beginnings were humble. A non-matriculate, Bapu was born in Birani village near Nawabshah in Pakistan's Sindh province before Partition forced his father Thaumal to flee to Ahmedabad when Bapu was seven years old. In his 20s, he tried to seek the blessings of Leelashah Baba, who died in 1973. His ashram is in Adipur in Kutch. Says Hemant Kumar Tolani, Leelashah Baba's disciple, "Asaram Bapu claims to be a disciple of Leelashah Baba. But the fact is that the baba never accepted him because he had severe reservations about him."

Bapu's ability to draw followers lies in a book called *Panchamrut*, a compilation of five major chapters



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